

Building Trust One Game at a Time

Throughout 2024 and 2025, Midwest Dairy recognized a valuable opportunity to strengthen trust in dairy by connecting with college athletic audiences. Collegiate athletics has become quite a large stage; some would say the popularity is rising to the same level as professional sports. These teams, schools, and athletes bring people together and create a community. Midwest dairy stepped right up on this stage by partnering with the Big 12 Conference through three major championship events: soccer, wrestling, and basketball. Using the power of sporting events to meet the right audience, young adults and their families, where they already are. With messaging that builds trust, relevance, and affinity for dairy.

Life without dairy isn't sustainable. So dairy is becoming more sustainable.

With a multi-sport and state partnership, Midwest Dairy used a mix of in-venue and TV-visible signage, digital marketing, fan engagement, and activations to bring dairy to the forefront-one moo at a time.

Starting in the fall of 2024 Midwest Dairy kicked off the partnership with the Sprouts Farmers Market Big 12 Conference Women's Soccer Championship. Hosted at the CPKC stadium in Kansas City, Missouri, the first stadium in the world built specifically for a professional women's team! The championship spanned four days, in which Midwest Dairy connected with 7,558 in-person attendees and 77,000 TV viewers, who collectively watched 3.7 million minutes of soccer. A mix of field-level signage and fun fan engagement, such as a cheesy dance and song activation, helped drive visibility. A branded "Big 12 Eats" menu featured hot chocolate made with dairy, which was a crowd favorite! The goal was to deliver memorable messages about dairy's sustainability and animal care, and that is exactly what happened. A 60 day post event digital marketing campaign reached mobile users with a click through rate between 0.3% and 0.47%, meeting the agriculture industry benchmarks. Notably, animal care messaging also drove 63% more clicks in December than in November, signaling strong consumer curiosity and a growing interest in dairy sustainability.

At the Big 12 Wrestling Championship in Tulsa, Oklahoma, Midwest Dairy greeted fans with a "Cozy Cow Lounge" at the BOK Center. Attendance hit a record breaking 21,309 across four ticketed sessions. 600 servings of free milk and cereal were given out to fans, and they participated in dairy trivia to win branded giveaways. Local dairy farmers Jack and Patty Dill even attended, helping bring authenticity to the messaging around animal care and farmer commitment. Dairy messaging reached fans via scoreboard engagement and on-mat signage, with "Be Legendary" prominently displayed during championship podium

moments. The “Big 12 Eats” menu featured dairy-rich items like the “12 Alarm Mat Burner” chili bowl and “Big 12 Slam pecan tart”. ESPN + viewership topped 669,000 offering major visibility for Midwest Dairy and Undeniably Dairy. A 30 day mobile ad campaign exceeded expectations with a 1% click through rate, which is more than double the industry benchmark, suggesting strong post event interest in learning more about dairy.

During the Phillips 66 Big 12 Women’s and Men’s basketball championships in Kansas City, dairy took the center stage for 10 days of engagement both inside T-Mobile Center and at the Big 12 BLVD Fan Fest, with a total attendance of 144,413 ticketed fans and millions more reached via TV and digital platforms, Midwest Dairy’s presence was everywhere. From courtside videoboards and food menus to interactive fan activities. “Big 12 Eats” featured 80% dairy-based menu items, with each of the 16 Big 12 schools represented through custom dishes. The women's tournament saw average game viewership rise 26%, while the men's games averaged 794,000 viewers, up 22% from 2024. USDairy.com even received live shoutouts and on-screen visibility during the men's championship, which drew 2.2 million viewers!

Dairy farmers Byron and Heidi Wells and Dwight and Anita Rokey attended with their families and were even recognized on the court during the women's and men’s quarterfinal games, they represented the sustainability of local dairy farms.

Dairy farmers aren’t just “important” to the industry; they are the industry.

Fan Fest activations included a “Moo-ve and Groove” silent disco, where 7,500 attendees experienced dairy-themed fun through multiple music channels, photobooths, and NIL athlete collaborations. Athletes from four Big 12 schools acted as “guest DJs” by having a few of their favorite tunes on the playlist. They also promoted the event through Instagram, generating over 393,000 impressions. A post-event digital campaign reached over 762,000 mobile users, with a .22% click through rate, aligning internal benchmarks. Importantly, 96% of surveyed participants said the Dairy Disco improved their perception of dairy's environmental sustainability.

Through its first-ever athletics conference partnership, Midwest Dairy made meaningful progress in building trust and deepening consumer understanding of dairy's role in sustainability. By meeting young adults and families where they are, at the heart of collegiate sports. Midwest dairy created authentic, engaging experiences that resonated across generations. With millions reached through in-person events, digital and televised exposure, this partnership with the Big 12 delivered a measurable impact. We hope that this momentum continues to strengthen trust in dairy and reinforce its relevance in the lives of today's and tomorrow's consumers, because life without dairy is unsustainable.